

Portfolio Review Guidelines

Rules for Inclusion, Revision & Exclusion of Design Work

Lantern Tides Studio · Design Operations · v1.0 · June 2026

01 — PURPOSE & SCOPE

Purpose & Scope

These guidelines govern the curation, assessment, and final selection of design pieces included in Lantern Tides Studio's portfolio review sets. They apply to all active designers, project leads, and external collaborators submitting work for client presentations, internal showcases, award entries, or platform publication.

Every design piece must be evaluated against the three-tier classification system defined in this document before it may appear in any review output:

Status	Meaning	Action Required
INCLUDE	Meets all criteria; approved for review set	Add to final output as-is
REVISE	Conditionally eligible; specific issues must be corrected first	Return to designer with feedback; re-review after fix
EXCLUDE	Does not qualify; removed from consideration	Log reason; do not include in any output

02 — INCLUSION CRITERIA

What Can Be Included

A design piece qualifies for the review set only when ALL of the following conditions are satisfied simultaneously. Partial compliance is treated as Needs Revision, not inclusion.

Formal Approval

The piece must carry a confirmed approved status from the designated reviewer. Verbal sign-offs, Slack reactions, and email acknowledgements without explicit approval language do not count. Approval must be logged in the Latest_Approval_Record.

Final Version on File

Only the highest version number of a file may be included. Earlier versions must be moved to the /Archive/ folder before the piece enters the review set. Source file and at least one export must both be present in the Design_File_Index.

Correct Client or Studio Attribution

The piece must be mapped to the correct project category (Freelance Client, Lantern Tides, or School Work) in the Project_Category_Map. Pieces whose attribution is ambiguous or mismatched are ineligible until corrected.

Clean Export with Correct Colour Profile

Web pieces must be exported in sRGB; print pieces in CMYK. Resolution must meet or exceed 72 DPI (web) or 300 DPI (print). Large-format outdoor pieces require a minimum of 150 DPI at final output size.

No Active Revision Requests

If any reviewer has raised an open comment or revision request against the piece — even a minor one — it may not enter the review set until that thread is formally closed and the status updated to Approved.

Rights & Permissions Cleared

Stock imagery, licensed typefaces, third-party illustrations, and client-provided assets must all be cleared for portfolio use. Written confirmation (email or signed release) must be on file.

Linked to a Live Project

Speculative or concept pieces may only be included if they are explicitly flagged as such and the project category is set to 'Lantern Tides — Concept'. Unlinked orphan files are excluded by default.

03 — REVISION CRITERIA

What Needs Revision Before Inclusion

The following issues do not disqualify a piece permanently but require the designer to correct and resubmit. A revised piece re-enters the standard review cycle and must receive a fresh Approved status before inclusion.

Issue	Required Correction	Turnaround
Wrong colour profile (e.g. RGB file submitted for print)	Re-export in correct profile; verify with preflight check	48 hrs
Resolution below spec	Re-export at required DPI; do not upscale artificially	48 hrs
Version mismatch (older version submitted)	Archive older versions; resubmit current final version	24 hrs
Missing export file (source only, no export)	Generate required export formats per Design_File_Index spec	24 hrs

Incorrect project category mapping	Update Project_Category_Map; confirm with project lead	24 hrs
Open reviewer comment not yet resolved	Address all comments; request reviewer to close thread	Per reviewer
Accessibility issues (e.g. contrast, font size)	Correct against WCAG AA minimum; re-export	72 hrs
Missing signed rights clearance	Obtain written permission for all third-party assets	Variable
Filename does not follow naming convention	Rename per [project]_[description]_v[N]_[status] convention	24 hrs
Bleed or crop marks absent on print file	Re-export with 3mm bleed and trim marks included	48 hrs

04 — EXCLUSION CRITERIA

What Must Be Excluded

The items below are permanently or situationally excluded from the review set. Exclusion is logged in the Latest_Approval_Record with status 'Excluded' and a reason code. Excluded items may not be reinstated without a formal re-review.

Permanently Excluded — No Appeal

- Wrong-client assets: Files belonging to a different client must never appear in another client's review output. Immediate removal; incident logged.
- Unapproved or rejected work: Any piece with status Rejected in the Latest_Approval_Record is excluded until formally redesigned and re-approved from scratch.
- Confidential or NDA-restricted work: Pieces covered by a non-disclosure agreement may only appear with explicit written client consent.
- Work produced by a third party without credit or license: Presenting others' work as studio output is a policy violation and grounds for disciplinary action.
- Pieces depicting minors or sensitive personal data: These are excluded for legal and ethical compliance regardless of design quality.

Excluded Due to Staleness

- Stale visual asset indexes: A visual index older than 90 days is considered outdated and must be regenerated before inclusion.
- Archived publishing calendars: Calendars that have been superseded by a newer version must not be used as scheduling evidence.
- Old caption drafts: Draft copy that was never approved and has been superseded by final copy is excluded as stale evidence.
- Duplicate post exports: If two files represent the same post, only the file with the higher version number and latest export date is eligible.

Excluded as Irrelevant Noise

- Internal meeting notes and team communications: Not design deliverables; excluded from all review outputs.
- Blank or placeholder templates: Templates with no completed content are not campaign-ready and must be excluded.
- Generic mood boards or inspiration decks: Unlicensed reference imagery and general idea documents are not original studio work.
- Office event or personal photography: Unrelated to client work or studio brand output; excluded by default.
- Scratch files and working drafts without a version suffix: Files named 'draft', 'test', 'untitled', or 'copy' are excluded until properly versioned.

05 — REVIEW DECISION FLOW

Step-by-Step Review Process

Reviewers must work through the following checklist sequentially for every design piece submitted to a review set. A piece advances to the next step only if it passes the current one.

Step	Action	Applies To
Step 1	Confirm the piece exists in the Latest_Approval_Record with a defined status.	All pieces
Step 2	Check for Excluded flags: wrong client, rejected, NDA, or stale. If found → Exclude.	All pieces
Step 3	Verify Approved status. If Pending or Needs Revision → do not include; return to designer.	All pieces
Step 4	Confirm the final version is on file in the Design_File_Index with at least one export.	All pieces
Step 5	Check colour profile and resolution against spec for the piece's output medium.	All pieces
Step 6	Verify correct client/project attribution in the Project_Category_Map.	All pieces
Step 7	Confirm rights clearance for all third-party assets used in the piece.	As applicable
Step 8	If all steps pass → assign Include status and add to review set output.	All pieces

06 — LINKED REFERENCE FILES

Supporting Documents

These guidelines are designed to be used in conjunction with the following tracker files. All cross-references in this document correspond to columns and fields defined in these files.

File	Purpose
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Latest_Approval_Record.csv	Authoritative source for approval status per design piece
Design_File_Index.csv	Lists all filenames, versions, formats, and export dates
Project_Category_Map.csv	Maps each piece to Freelance Client, Lantern Tides, or School Work
Portfolio_Item_Tracker.csv	Master register of all portfolio items with linked piece IDs

07 — AMENDMENTS & VERSION CONTROL

Policy Updates

This document is version-controlled. Any proposed amendment must be submitted to the Design Operations lead for review. Approved amendments take effect from the date of the next issued version. Designers are responsible for checking that they are working from the current version of this document before beginning any portfolio review cycle.

Version	Date	Author	Summary of Changes
1.0	June 2026	Design Ops	Initial release

Questions regarding interpretation of these guidelines should be directed to the Design Operations lead. In cases of ambiguity, the most conservative interpretation (i.e., Exclude or Revise rather than Include) applies until formal clarification is issued.